

CSCI 4600: Senior Seminar

Fall 2026 Syllabus

Instructor: Dr. Vincent A. Cicirello

E-mail (course related): Use course Blackboard Course Messages tool.

E-mail (other than this course): See campus directory for address.

Office: USC2-313

Phone (office): x3526

Course Time and Location:

- Tuesday, 10:30am-12:20pm, B105 (attendance is mandatory).
- This is a 2-credit course, which is why it meets for 2 hours per week.
- If you don't attend a class session, you will lose part of your participation/attendance grade.

Office Hours:

- Thursday 10:30am - 12:00noon (Office: USC2-313)
- Wednesday 10:00am – 3:00pm (Zoom by appointment)
- Other days/times by appointment either in my office or via Zoom.
- You can also just drop by my office, and if I'm there I'm happy to assist you.

Course Description:

In this seminar, computer science majors learn to evaluate the impact of current computing practice and trends; and gain an understanding of professional, ethical, and legal responsibilities. Students read and report on articles from the computing literature, and also develop a professional resume.

Pre-reqs: Minimum grade of C in the following CSCI 3103, CSCI 3250, CSCI 2226, and MATH 2216.

Restrictions: Juniors/Seniors only, and Computer Science majors

Number of Credits: 2

This course fulfills Stockton University's Values/Ethics (V) requirement.

Core Course: This course is a core required course for the B.S. in Computer Science, and must be passed with at least a C to count toward your degree requirements.

Required Readings:

- ACM Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct
(<https://www.acm.org/binaries/content/assets/about/acm-code-of-ethics-and-professional-conduct.pdf>)
- Journal articles and conference papers; and Computing ethics case studies

Other Requirements:

The multipart exam requires Respondus Lockdown Browser with webcam (either one built into your laptop or external). I have a fake test in Blackboard that you can use to make sure Respondus Lockdown is working correctly. I strongly suggest that you use that fake test. I will not reopen parts of the exam if you claim to have technical problems with the real exam, but never tried the fake test. The settings that I'm using also won't work with an iPad. See the help desk if you need to borrow a laptop. All campus labs have Respondus Lockdown installed. To install on your personal device, either follow the link in Blackboard or here: <https://download.respondus.com/lockdown/download.php?id=353467840>.

Computer Science Student Outcomes:

This course supports students in their development of the following Computer Science student outcomes:

- Outcome 3: An ability to communicate effectively in a variety of professional contexts.
 - 3.b: Students will create and present oral technical presentations.
 - 3.c: Students will write technical reports on a current computing topic.
- Outcome 4: An ability to recognize professional responsibilities and make informed judgments in computing practice based on legal and ethical principles.
 - 4.a: Students will know the ACM Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct.
 - 4.b: Students will evaluate case studies of ethical dilemmas in computing.
 - 4.c: Students will demonstrate understanding of intellectual property issues.

Course IDEA Objectives:

The IDEA objectives of this course include:

- Gaining a basic understanding of the subject (e.g., ACM Code of Ethics, introduction to intellectual property laws and issues, etc).
- Developing skill in expressing myself orally or in writing (e.g., writing and presenting on a current computing topic).
- Learning how to find, evaluate, and use resources to explore a topic in depth.
- Developing ethical reasoning and/or ethical decision making.
- Learning to analyze and critically evaluate ideas, arguments, and points of view.

Grading:

Attendance / participation:	15%
Exam (ethics, intellectual property, license agreements, etc)	25%
Annotated bibliography:	25%
Presentation:	20%
Professional resume:	15%

Grading Scale:

Letter grade and range	Letter grade and range	Letter grade and range
A: at least 90.00	A-: at least 89.50	B+: at least 89.00
B: at least 80.00	B-: at least 79.50	C+: at least 79.00
C: at least 70.00	D: at least 60.00	F: less than 60.00

Note: The chart above deliberately does not include C-, D+, or D-. Those grades are not used in this course.

Another note: I reserve the right to adjust the scale at the end of the semester. Such adjustments are rare, but will only be in your favor; and are highly unlikely to occur at the C/D or D/F boundaries. Note the 2 decimal places in the chart above (i.e., I do not round to the nearest whole number): e.g., unless I adjust the grade scale, an 89.99 is an A-, etc. If I adjust the scale, it is done using a semi-automated approach involving clustering (i.e., “automated” == a program I wrote suggests a new scale based on all of the grades of the class; “semi-” == if that program’s output is crazy, I ignore it and leave the scale alone; and “clustering” == a statistical technique). I never simply add a constant number of points to everyone’s overall course score. What is clustering? For a non-technical explanation, consider the hypothetical question, “Are the grades of this student, who is currently in the B range, more like the grades of the A students, more like the grades of the rest of the B students, or somewhere in between the two?” Clustering may take a student in the B range from the scale above (at least 80.00), and either keep them in the B range if their grades are more like the rest of the B students, or bump them all the way up to the A range if their grades are more like the A students, or bump them partially up to either B+ or A- if they are somewhere in between.

Attendance and Participation:

This portion of your grade is not free points. Attendance is mandatory. Participation includes interacting with student speakers and any guest speakers, as well as participating in all in-class activities, which may include peer-review/peer-editing of resumes, annotated bibliographies, etc. Participation also includes interacting with student presenters (asking questions, etc). If you miss class due to illness, please document when you are able to return to your classes to avoid losing attendance/participation points. Provide the documentation of your illness to Stockton's Wellness Center and ask them to contact your instructors. Likewise, if you will miss class due to a religious holiday, you must inform me of the dates of those absences in writing (e.g., message in Blackboard is fine) within the first 10 business days of the semester per Stockton procedure: <https://stockton.edu/policy-procedure/documents/procedures/2030.pdf>.

Minimum Effect of Unexcused Absence: The participation points are equally distributed across days when the class meets. Each unexcused absence on a day when students are presenting or on a day when students peer-review assignment drafts results in a loss of the points for **two (2)** class days. Arriving late enough on the day of a guest speaker to miss most of their presentation, results in losing the points for a full class period. Unexcused absences on other class days result in a loss of the points for one (1) class day. Signing the attendance sheet and then leaving is ignorant, and will lose the points for **two (2)** class days.

Exam on Ethics and Intellectual Property:

There will be one exam in the course that will cover computing ethics, including specifically the ACM Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct, as well as Intellectual Property, including licensing agreements. See the schedule at the end of the syllabus. **The exam is closed book and closed notes. You are not allowed to use any resources during the exam.** The majority of the exam is multiple choice, true/false, short answer type questions (which is why you are not allowed notes---it would be far too easy with notes). However, there is one essay question involving an ethics case study. That essay question involves reading a short case study involving an ethical dilemma, and writing a 3 to 5 paragraph essay in response to a question about that case study. In your response to that essay question, you should utilize the ACM Code of Ethics, wherever appropriate, in support of your analysis. I will provide an abridged version of the ACM Code of Ethics within the exam itself. You are not allowed to use your own copy or the full version.

Make-Up Exam: Make-up exams will not be given (i.e., missed exam = 0), with the following exceptions:

1. Medical excuse: Provide documentation to the Wellness Center who will then contact all of the instructors of your courses.
2. Based on University policy (<https://stockton.edu/policy-procedure/documents/procedures/2030.pdf>), if you are to be absent for a religious holiday on the date of an exam, you must notify me of that planned absence during the first 10 business days of the semester. But, please note that since I'm giving you a 3-day window within which to take each part of the exam, a religious holiday excuse will only result in a make-up exam if the religious observance covers the entire 3-day window.
3. The exam is divided into 3 parts and will be taken via Blackboard at the time of your choosing within a 3-day window. Each part is accessible beginning at the end of a class session and available until 11:59pm on Friday. Each part has a strict time limit. It will auto-submit if you either run out of time or at 11:59pm on Friday, whichever comes first. Starting by 11:59pm Friday is NOT sufficient. You must be finished by that time.

Annotated Bibliography:

During the semester, you will write an annotated bibliography, including summaries and your analysis of a minimum of 5 technical articles (from journals or peer-reviewed conferences) from any topic of computing of your choosing. Your analysis of the articles you read should include a discussion of the potential impact that the research has on individuals, organizations, or society as a whole. The ACM Digital Library,

available through the Stockton University library website, is an excellent source of articles, although you are not limited to what is contained there.

Presentation:

During the last several weeks of the semester, each student will give a presentation (approximately 15 minutes) discussing one or more of the articles that you read. Your presentation should make appropriate use of PowerPoint and/or other relevant presentation materials. Shortly after the drop-add period is over, I will enable a signup page in Blackboard where you will get to choose the date of your presentation on a first come first served basis. You will lose substantial attendance/participation points if you do not attend on days when students are presenting (you will lose more points on such a day than if you miss class on another day). You will have the opportunity to ask each other questions about your presentations, so make sure you are also prepared to answer each other's questions.

Professional Resume:

You will develop (or revise, if you already have one) a professional resume. You can find detailed expectations in Blackboard.

Limited Use of Generative A.I. (read carefully before using Generative A.I.):

Generative artificial intelligence (AI) programs, such as ChatGPT, may be used in this course to brainstorm or learn more about a topic, draft an outline or organize thoughts, check grammar, or improve writing style, with appropriate citation complying with Stockton's Student Academic Honesty Procedure. You are responsible for fact checking statements composed by generative AI models and respecting intellectual property. Generative AI may not be used for writing your annotated bibliography or portions of it, or for creating your presentation. If you are uncertain about the appropriate use of generative AI in this course, you are encouraged to contact your instructor for clarification. Inappropriate use of generative AI programs is not permitted and will be treated as plagiarism as defined in Stockton's Student Academic Honesty Procedure and handled in accordance with that Procedure and the course's Academic Honesty Procedure (see below). **You are NOT ALLOWED to use Generative AI for any purpose on the essay part of the exam.**

Late Policy:

Assignments are graded on a 100 point scale. Penalty is 1 point for each hour (or part of an hour) late. For example, submit 10 hours late and lose 10 points. Submit 1.25 hours late, and lose 2 points. Submit an assignment a full day late and lose 24 points off the assignment's grade.

Incomplete Policy:

In general, no grades of incomplete will be given. The only exception to this rule is an institutionally documented medical emergency that necessitates your complete absence from Stockton for at least two continuous semester weeks. Additionally, you must be caught up on all work up to the point where your medical emergency began and currently in the "C" range or better overall at the point where the emergency began.

Academic Honesty:

Please familiarize yourself with Stockton's Student Academic Honesty Procedure. Each violation is penalized by a 0 on the relevant assignment/exam/etc, plus a 10 point penalty on your overall course grade. For example, if you have one violation, you'll have a 0 on that assignment or exam plus 10 points off your overall average, but if you have two violations, you'll have grades of 0 on the two assignments/exams/etc and 20 points off your overall average. Example violations include, but are not limited to: (a) any form of cheating on an exam or assignment, (b) passing off the work of another as your own (including other

students, former students, websites, ChatGPT and other Generative A.I.), (c) assisting someone in violating the academic honesty procedure, (d) asking someone to assist you in cheating or other academic honesty violations (even if they refuse to help you cheat), etc. [Yes, I encountered that last one once in a General Studies course.] **Reminder from earlier in syllabus: the exam is closed notes, and you are not allowed any resources during the exam. Another reminder from earlier in the syllabus: limited use of generative AI tools, such as ChatGPT, is allowed. If you use it in the ways allowed by that section of the syllabus, then it is not an academic honesty violation.**

Timeline:

The following chart indicates approximately what we will be doing during each class meeting, as well as assignment deadlines. This timeline is subject to change based on unforeseen circumstances.

Date (Tuesdays)	Topic/Activity	Important Dates
September 8	Course Overview	
September 15	Computing ethics	
September 22	Computing ethics (Spencer's Visit)	
September 29	Computing ethics / Intellectual property	Exam Part 1 due Oct 2, 11:59pm Exam Part 2 due Oct 2, 11:59pm
October 6	Peer review and feedback on annotated bibliography drafts. See Blackboard for expectations on draft. Draft due by class time (3 paper copies in class, and electronic copy in Blackboard)	
October 13	Intellectual property	
October 20	Intellectual property	Exam Part 3 due Oct 23, 11:59pm
October 27	NO CLASS: Precepting Day	
November 3	Tips on Resume Writing	Final version of annotated bibliography due 11:59pm, November 6
November 10	Student presentations*	
November 17	Student presentations*	
November 24	Student presentations*	
December 1	Student presentations*	
December 8	Student presentations*	
		Resume due December 15, 11:59pm

* Your slides from your presentation are due electronically in Blackboard by 11:59pm on the day that you present.